

“Aviation is fine as sport...
But as an instrument of
war, it is worthless.”

GENERAL FERDINAND FOCH
PROFESSOR OF STRATEGY,
ÉCOLE SUPÉRIURE DE GUERRE, 1911

MILITARY TRIALS

Army Airship “Beta” passing over British troops during maneuvers in Micheldever in 1910. This was a trial to test the potential use of airships as aerial scouts for recording troop positions. However, it was unsuccessful – the airships were too big and cumbersome, and kept landing in “enemy territory.”

governments back aircraft development, both as a symbol of national pride and an instrument of war.

Europe’s army and navy officers were more skeptical than the public about the effectiveness of flying machines. French general Ferdinand Foch, a gifted military strategist who could certainly not be dismissed as a blindered conservative, nonetheless expressed the opinion that aviation was a fine sport, but a worthless instrument of war. Yet there were some senior officers who embraced aviation with enthusiasm. In 1910, the French War Ministry was informed by one of its generals that airplanes were “as indispensable to armies as cannon or rifles.” Even those who did not welcome the revolutionary new technology soon bowed to its inevitability. The British general staff regretfully acknowledged that it was impossible to “arrest or retard the perhaps unwelcome progress of aerial navigation.” Expecting a major war at any moment, no army or navy could afford to neglect exploring the potential of flight.

But what precisely were military aircraft to be used for? One of the most influential fantasy novels of the period, H.G. Wells’ *The War in the Air* (1908), imagined German airships crossing

